



The Danube

One of Europe's great waterways, linking the west of the continent to the east, crossing and forming many borders

Europe's second longest river, after the Volga, the Danube forms at the confluence of the Brege and Brigach Rivers in the Black Forest, in southwest Germany. Over a long journey eastward to its mouth at the Black Sea, the river flows a total of 1,770 miles (2,860 km). The Danube can lay claim to being the most international river in the world. It passes through, or partly borders, 10 countries—more than any other river—and its huge drainage basin includes parts of nine others.

Three courses

The course of the Danube is often divided into three major sections. The upper course runs from its source eastward across southern Germany and northern Austria to the Devin Gate, a natural gorge east of Vienna. At the start of its middle section, the river slows down and deposits large amounts of gravel and sand. Turning south, it flows through Budapest and across the Great Hungarian Plain to become a border between Romania



and Serbia, where its banks narrow into a series of towering limestone cliffs known as the Iron Gate. The Danube's lower course becomes wider and shallower as it starts its journey across a broad, flat plain. As the river approaches the Black Sea, it winds north around the Dobruja Hills before turning east, splitting into three main distributaries and forming Europe's second largest delta after the Volga.

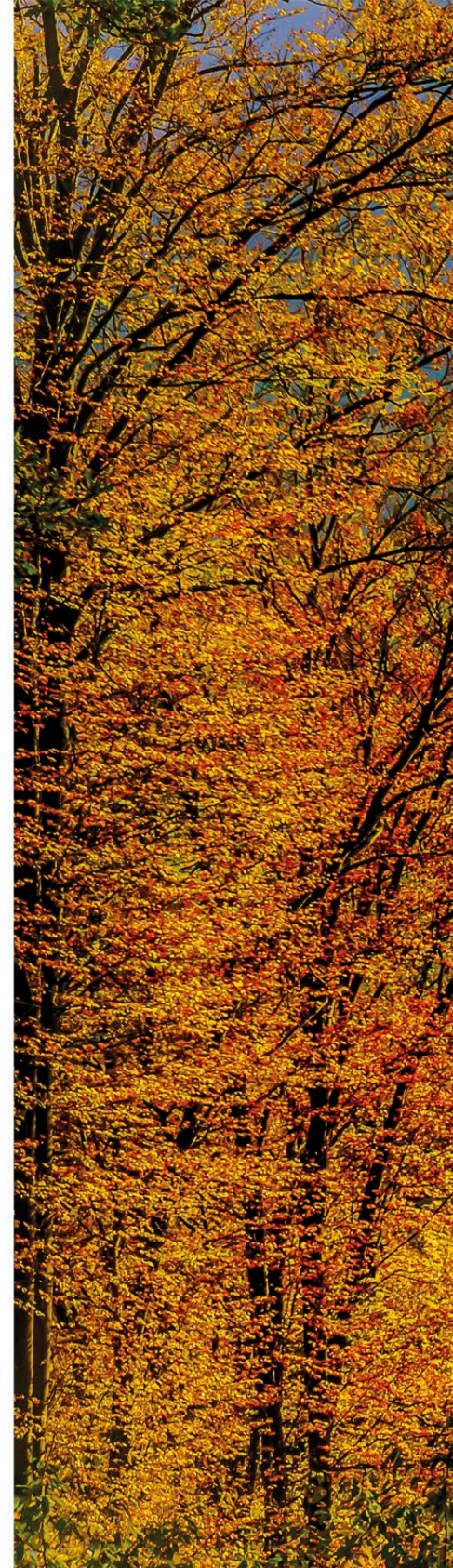
Vital artery

The Danube has played a central role in the social and economic history of Central and Eastern Europe. At some times, it has formed the border between territories; at others, it has been a vital link allowing the flow of commerce between nations, enabling the countries it crosses to thrive.

◀ BRIGHT FROG

Pool frogs live in ponds, lakes, and slow-moving rivers over much of Europe. Those found in Central and Southern Europe are often a brighter green than their western cousins.

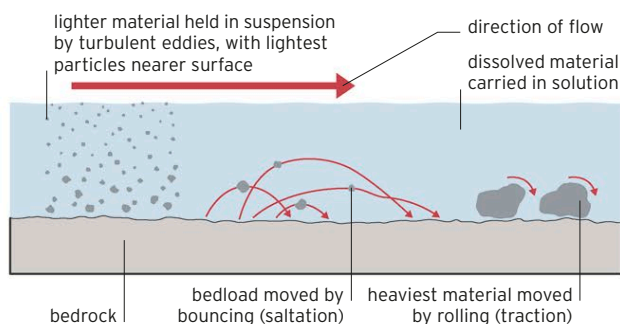
The Danube is the **only major European river** that flows **west to east** from Central to Eastern Europe



HOW RIVERS TRANSPORT SEDIMENT

The amount of material that a river is able to transport depends on the energy of its waters and the size of the material. While dissolved materials are carried in solution, the smallest particles, such as clay and silt, are suspended in the water column when its currents are strong enough. Larger items of sediment that are not held in suspension are called its bedload.

When a river has enough energy, it can transport smaller bedload by pushing or bouncing it along the riverbed. Rivers with high energy levels and strong currents—during a flash flood, for example—can move boulders by rolling them downstream.



△ CHANGING HABITATS

Over its long course, the Danube passes through a variety of habitats, including deciduous woodland, coniferous forests, semiarid plains, and marshland.

▷ PELICAN HAVEN

Home to 70 percent of the world's white pelican population, the Danube Delta is a key sanctuary for more than 300 bird species.